

How deep does this go?

I'M A TYPICAL CITY-SLICHER WHO SPENT TOO MUCH TIME IN METROPOLITAN AREAS AND NOT ENOUGH TIME IN NATURE IN HIS YOUTH, which means I jump at the sight of critters, I can't stand caves and dark places and I'm claustrophobic – which is surprising, because growing up in crowded Indian cities, you'd think I'd be used to tight squeezes!

Yet, for someone so claustrophobic, I seem to be diving down rabbit holes way too often for my own good. And no I'm not some eager Beagle who actually dives down rabbit holes... I'm, of course, talking about internet rabbit holes.

A 'rabbit hole' is a reference to Lewis Carroll's masterpiece of writing, *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*. In the novel, Carroll (real name Charles Lutwidge Dodgson) writes a fantastic tale of a girl called Alice who falls into a rabbit hole and ends up in a magical world called Wonderland. On the internet, 'going down the rabbit hole' is when you find something new and intriguing, going down the path of learning things that are often pointless and strange, very rarely useful, but addictive as heck!

Of course, some can be very fun, like *notpron.com* which is an internet game that was the inspiration for our own Crack the Code game that lakhs of you have enjoyed over the years. Then there are conspiracy theories, weird beliefs, cults, Google Earth hunters, and more.

(Google Earth hunting is something people have been doing ever since Google Earth launched in 2001, and it's basically people scouring through satellite images of Google Earth to try and find something interesting.)

Rabbit holes are essentially anything that one can stumble across on the internet which seem innocuous, and then you search a little more, and find something intriguing, and so on until before you know it, a week has gone by and you're just a little obsessed with learning about something pointless.

Case in point: I decided to make a new Facebook account, just to wipe out the algorithm's dossier on me, and be exposed to new things. Those of you who have added me on Facebook might have seen the "fake profile" too. One of those new things was a random post from a Flat Earth believers group. I clicked join, because who wouldn't right?

Once accepted into the group, I've been down a rabbit hole of ridiculous beliefs, long,

drawn-out videos of people making an earnest case of why they believe they are being lied to by the world, and how the earth is really flat. Most are Americans (of course), and religious, but some are truly intriguing. Like supposed ex-scientists who otherwise display a knowledge of science, yet will argue against it. It's like watching drunk people make fools of themselves. It's totally pointless and serves no purpose, but my word, you cannot look away for a second, as you're hooked on the idiocy!

Of course, since the Earth being flat means that every space agency is lying to the public, and there are complex theories they have developed to explain why that is so... the moon landing was faked, all pictures of the earth from space are photoshopped, and some even truly believe that there is no southern hemisphere! Fascinating, of course, because as I now live in Australia, I am literally reading about how I don't exist, or that I am in a place that doesn't exist!

Now, rabbit holes aren't always this insane. And honestly, following a rabbit hole does seem so much more fun (to me at least) as compared to doomscrolling on Instagram or YouTube (or TikTok in Australia). Of course one can come across a rabbit hole when doomscrolling or doomsurfing as well, or as the kids are now calling it, gleefreshing (a play on the word refreshing). A new word because the kids think they're looking for happy and positive videos which makes them gleeful, I suppose. My own term for it is scrollololing (scrolling for lols), but that's never going to catch on.

Like I said, not all rabbit holes are pointless, or dead ends. I picked up a few carpentry tricks down one hole, and some guitar tips down another, which I have actually used. There are coding rabbit holes that those with dev skills can explore, and rabbit holes for math nerds, science nerds, and more. No matter how freaky your mind is, with five billion people online, chances are there are at least a few hundred thousand people who are into something weird that will interest you. Some of it will be pointless, some disturbing, and some will help you develop a new skill, or meet interesting people, or even fall in love! There's a rabbit hole out there about couples who met while going down rabbit holes, surely! And the best part? Recession or no recession, rabbit holes are always free! Let us know if you find any really interesting ones. 



"You find something new and intriguing, and then follow down the path learning things that are often pointless and strange."



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